Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God

Jonathan Edwards · July 8, 1741 (Enfield, Connecticut)

Source: Jonathan Edwards, Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God (1741), text via Project Gutenberg (#34632). Public domain.

Preached at the height of the First Great Awakening, Edwards's sermon used vivid, terrifying imagery to drive listeners toward personal conversion. The Awakening's emotional, revivalist style swept the colonies, challenged established churches, and created a shared religious experience that crossed colonial lines — an early step toward a common colonial identity.

Connect: How did the emotional, revivalist style of the Great Awakening differ from an older Puritan sermon like Winthrop's?

Key Passages

Nothing but God's pleasure

> There is nothing that keeps wicked men at any one moment out of hell, but the mere pleasure of God. … There is nothing between you and hell but the air; 'tis only the power and mere pleasure of God that holds you up.

The spider over the fire

> The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked; his wrath towards you burns like fire; … You have offended him infinitely more than ever a stubborn rebel did his prince: and yet it is nothing but his hand that holds you from falling into the fire every moment.

A call to conversion

> And now you have an extraordinary opportunity, a day wherein Christ has flung the door of mercy wide open, and stands in the door calling and crying with a loud voice to poor sinners; … How awful is it to be left behind at such a day! To see so many others feasting, while you are pining and perishing! … Therefore let every one that is out of Christ now awake and fly from the wrath to come.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The First Great Awakening (1730s-40s): revivals swept the colonies, challenging established churches and the cooler, more rational religion of the Enlightenment era.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	His congregation and the Enfield, Connecticut, church audience, whom he saw as spiritually complacent and unconverted; it was later printed for a wider readership.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Jonathan Edwards, a Calvinist minister and theologian and leading revivalist, who believed people were saved only by God's grace through a personal conversion.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the First Great Awakening on colonial society.
2. Why might Edwards's vivid imagery have been so effective with his audience?
3. How did the Great Awakening help create a shared identity across the separate colonies?

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> The most famous sermon of the Great Awakening: with vivid images of sinners dangled like a spider over the fire, Edwards preached that only God's mercy holds the unconverted from hell — stirring a wave of emotional religious revival.

Text and doctrine

DEUTERONOMY xxxii. 35.—Their foot shall slide in due time. . . . The observation from the words that I would now insist upon is this, There is nothing that keeps wicked men at any one moment out of hell, but the mere pleasure of God. By the mere pleasure of God, I mean his sovereign pleasure, his arbitrary will, restrained by no obligation, hindered by no manner of difficulty, any more than if nothing else but God’s mere will had in the least degree or in any respect whatsoever any hand in the preservation of wicked men one moment.

[. . .]

Nothing but God’s pleasure

So that thus it is, that natural men are held in the hand of God over the pit of hell; they have deserved the fiery pit, and are already sentenced to it; and God is dreadfully provoked, his anger is as great towards them as to those that are actually suffering the executions of the fierceness of his wrath in hell, and they have done nothing in the least to appease or abate that anger, neither is God in the least bound by any promise to hold ’em up one moment; the devil is waiting for them, hell is gaping for them, the flames gather and flash about them, and would fain lay hold on them and swallow them up; the fire pent up in their own hearts is struggling to break out; and they have no interest in any Mediator, there are no means within reach that can be any security to them. In short they have no refuge, nothing to take hold of; all that preserves them every moment is the mere arbitrary will, and uncovenanted, unobliged forbearance of an incensed God.

[. . .]

Application

The use may be of awakening to unconverted persons in this congregation. This that you have heard is the case of every one of you that are out of Christ. That world of misery, that lake of burning brimstone, is extended abroad under you. There is the dreadful pit of the glowing flames of the wrath of God; there is hell’s wide gaping mouth open; and you have nothing to stand upon, nor any thing to take hold of. There is nothing between you and hell but the air; ’tis only the power and mere pleasure of God that holds you up. . . . The bow of God’s wrath is bent, and the arrow made ready on the string, and justice bends the arrow at your heart, and strains the bow, and it is nothing but the mere pleasure of God, and that of an angry God, without any promise or obligation at all, that keeps the arrow one moment from being made drunk with your blood.

[. . .]

The spider over the fire

The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked; his wrath towards you burns like fire; he looks upon you as worthy of nothing else, but to be cast into the fire; he is of purer eyes than to bear to have you in his sight; you are ten thousand times so abominable in his eyes, as the most hateful and venomous serpent is in ours. You have offended him infinitely more than ever a stubborn rebel did his prince: and yet it is nothing but his hand that holds you from falling into the fire every moment.

[. . .]

A call to conversion

And now you have an extraordinary opportunity, a day wherein Christ has flung the door of mercy wide open, and stands in the door calling and crying with a loud voice to poor sinners; a day wherein many are flocking to him and pressing into the Kingdom of God. Many are daily coming from the east, west, north and south; many that were very likely in the same miserable condition that you are in are in now a happy state, with their hearts filled with love to him that has loved them and washed them from their sins in his own blood, and rejoicing in hope of the glory of God. How awful is it to be left behind at such a day! To see so many others feasting, while you are pining and perishing! To see so many rejoicing and singing for joy of heart, while you have cause to mourn for sorrow of heart and howl for vexation of spirit! How can you rest for one moment in such a condition? Are not your souls as precious as the souls of the people at Suffield, where they are flocking from day to day to Christ? . . . Therefore let every one that is out of Christ now awake and fly from the wrath to come.

Words to know

sovereign pleasure — God's absolute will, answerable to no one

natural men — people who have not been converted or saved

Mediator — Christ, who stands between sinners and God's wrath

forbearance — patient holding back of punishment

unconverted — not yet having had a saving religious experience

brimstone — burning sulfur; the fire of hell